

Eternal Cycle Publishing · Krasnoyarsk · 1979
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Café de la Luna · Kids’ Series

Book III

In the Margins of the Stars

Evgeniy Tyurkin, Luna, Muse

Publication details

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Contents

1. Between the First Row and the Last

2. The First of December

3. The Earth on the Desk

4. A Point of Light Was Enough

5. A Timetable for the Sky

6. The Rules of a Folded Sheet

7. Minor Repairs to Winter

8. An Honest Line

9. Coordinates Without Degrees

10. One Book a Day

11. A Day Without Lecture Notes

12. Eight O'Clock

A Note from the Authors

A Question Without a Signature

What will you leave room for, even if you cannot name it yet?

1. Between the First Row and the Last

In September 2001, Slava Serov learned to arrive at lectures seven minutes early.

Seven minutes was enough to take off his cap, smooth its pointlessly oversized peak across his knees, get out his notebook, and stop wondering where to put his legs. His elder brother's trousers were too long for him. The turn-ups were held in place by sheer goodwill and two stitches Slava had put in himself; the goodwill was doing the better job. The jacket was his brother's too, but the notebook was his own: forty-eight leaves of

squared paper. On the cover he had written only his surname. A first name had seemed excessive.

The seat in the far right-hand corner of the large lecture hall had every necessary advantage: he could see the board and the door, and almost nobody could see him.

He had turned twenty-six that year. He was finishing university and still felt that someone had lent him an age to wear along with the jacket. Whenever there was a socket to mend, a load to calculate, or a missed topic to explain to a fellow student, his age fitted perfectly. It was only conversations without a

predetermined subject that made it uncomfortable.

[1] Lisa Ladina arrived differently. She managed to appear half a minute before the lecturer and still seem unhurried. Her two dark braids began each day intending to be tidy and abandoned the intention almost at once. She wore trainers and a plain pair of work overalls. The bib pocket held a notebook, a pen, a folded note; once Slava had spotted a small screwdriver there.

Lisa was twenty-four. She sat at the front on the left, closer to the person who would have to answer the questions.

They were not in the same class. Several shared lectures a week brought students from different courses into this hall; at other times their timetables diverged like tramlines after a shared stop. They knew each other by sight. Lisa had nodded to Slava a couple of times in the corridor; once he had held a door for her. That was their entire shared history, apart from having lived in the same city for several years without ever taking advantage of it.

At the first lecture that September, the lecturer drew an ideal system on the board.

"We'll disregard external influences," he said.

Lisa raised her hand.

"Where is it?"

"What?"

"The system. If nothing is acting on it."

The lecturer put down the chalk.

"In our argument, Lisa."

"Oh, that makes sense. I thought there might actually be somewhere like that."

She laughed with everyone else, without needing to win. Then she carefully wrote down the answer. That was what Slava noticed: she wasn't collecting other people's awkward moments. She

genuinely wanted to know how things worked.

[2] The next time, she asked why a useful approximation stopped being useful at precisely the point where things grew interesting. Then who had first spotted the error in a famous model. Then how to tell a faulty instrument from an astonishing result.

"Start by assuming the instrument is faulty," the lecturer advised.

"And then?"

"Then check."

"And then can we be astonished?"

"If you've any strength left."

Lisa always had.

Slava began noticing her in the spaces between the formulae. She listened with her head tilted slightly, as though a complicated explanation were a quiet sound. When she understood, her face lit up before her hand began to write. On another woman's face he might have remembered lipstick, or earrings. With Lisa he remembered the moment of understanding. He would have had nothing against lipstick or earrings; this was simply what he had seen first.

Once, after a lecture, one of her friends complained about a bad purchase: a pair of shoes.

"But they're pretty," said another.

Lisa crouched down, examined the strap, and took a safety pin from her pocket.

"They can stay pretty. But if we move this bit, they won't rub so much."

Slava liked that she hadn't suggested choosing between beauty and being able to walk.

By November he knew which hand she used to hold back her braid when she bent over her notebook. He knew she carried apples and never finished one on the move: she stopped, as if an apple were entitled to time of its own. He knew that in the library

she looked for books that weren't on the reading list.

He didn't know how to speak to her.

"Hello" seemed too small a beginning for something that already took up so much room. "I like the way you ask questions" sounded suspiciously like a lecturer's assessment. "May I sit beside you?" was dangerous because she might perfectly well answer, "Of course." After that he would actually have to sit down.

Autumn was wearing thin. Beyond the windows, Volgograd stretched along the Volga like a long thought nobody could quite finish saying. The heating came

on in the lecture hall. Lisa began leaving her jacket over the back of her chair, and sometimes her notebook on the desk.

Slava could see the empty margins of her notes.

Little by little, and quite wrongly, he began to think of them as a place where it might be easier for him to exist.



2. The First of December

On the morning of the first of December, Lisa left her notebook open on her desk and went into the corridor for water.

Nothing momentous happened. Voices didn't fall silent; clocks didn't stop. Someone was looking for chalk, someone was arguing about an upcoming assessment, a chair scraped on the other side of the wall. Afterwards, it was this ordinariness that astonished Slava most: life had allowed him to do something without giving him a single warning signal.

The day before, he had seen Lisa asking for a Jules Verne novel in the library. The copy she wanted was out on loan, and the librarian had promised it would soon be returned. Slava remembered the title because he had read the book as a child too, although what he chiefly recalled was electric rifles and the fact that Captain Nemo was rarely in a good mood.

He went over to the front row on the left as if to fetch a timetable. A red pen seemed to find its own way out of his pocket: he used it to correct calculations. For the rest of his life he would distrust the phrase "of its own accord."

In the outer margin, beside a neatly written definition, he wrote:

Library. Twenty Thousand Leagues Under the Sea.

[3] His hand shook on the last letter. He returned to his seat. His heart was working as though it had been entrusted with supplying blood to the whole back row, rather than just one person.

The plan was simple, almost absurdly so: she would borrow the book, and he would have time to leave a note inside. It was easier to begin a conversation in a book. People were already talking to one another across

distances and years there; nobody found paper surprising.

Only when Lisa came back did he realise that he hadn't yet left the note, and had no idea which copy she would be given.

The lecture began.

Lisa opened her notebook, ran a finger along the line where she had stopped, and saw the red writing.

Her expression didn't change. She finished the date, underlined the heading, and began on the definition. The lecturer could have been proud of her at that moment: every word went in its place, not a symbol was missed. Meanwhile, inside Lisa, an

investigative bureau had opened for business.

First: someone else had written in her notebook.

Second: this person had information about the book.

Third: there had been absolutely no need to use a red pen.

She turned the page to check for more. There was no more. This annoyed her. Intrusion without explanation is a particular kind of rudeness, even when the territory invaded is only a centimetre and a half of paper margin.

Lisa surveyed the hall as though checking whether the lecturer

could be heard from the back. Suspicion fell on three people: a habitual prankster, someone who was forever borrowing pens, and a neighbour who had overheard her conversation in the library. The last was immediately ruled out: different handwriting. So was the prankster: he couldn't have lasted five minutes without smirking.

Slava Serov sat in the right-hand corner, diligently drawing a diagram. Lisa ruled him out almost at once. He never took up more space than he was entitled to, and barely managed to occupy even that. Imagining him at someone else's notebook was

rather like suspecting a library bookmark of robbery.

She turned away. Slava finally breathed in.

[4] "Library" might be a meeting place. But why no time? And why the title of her favourite book? Lisa disliked puzzles that depended on the author simply having forgotten to supply half the conditions. Here, though, the missing half seemed deliberate.

A fraction appeared on the board. Lisa copied it without error.

Twenty thousand leagues.

A league was a measure of length. Nautical? French? Reference books gave different answers. At

roughly four kilometres, that made eighty thousand.

Under the sea.

What if it wasn't a title? What if it was an address?

The thought made her feel excited and uneasy: not frightened, but the way you feel when you discover an extra door in a familiar room. She suppressed a smile in case the lecturer took it as a response to the fraction.

"Under the sea" could mean "down." Down from the surface, on through the Earth, all the way through. Eighty thousand kilometres minus the planet's diameter…

On a separate scrap, Lisa wrote a number: approximately sixty-seven thousand two hundred and fifty-eight kilometres above the other side.

It proved nothing. She knew that. The word "approximately" could be put before every step in this calculation, including the very first. But the thought had already gathered speed.

Space.

For a second, Lisa stopped hearing the lecture. Her hand kept writing: she had long been able to maintain the thread of her notes while another thought attended to its own business.

At that same moment, Slava was thinking only about the library. He had a lunch break, a red pen, and a need to get ahead of his own courage before it changed its mind.

3. The Earth on the Desk

Lisa had had the globe since she was ten.

It wasn't particularly accurate: some of the borders had changed, and the mountains stood out as though the whole planet suffered from a small but determined rash. On metal arms beside the Earth were two little lamps, the Sun and the Moon. They could be moved around to demonstrate day, night, and eclipses, which in Lisa's hands occurred considerably more often than nature intended.

Her father had given it to her before his last voyage. By then, Jules Verne's book had been her favourite for four years.

"So you won't think the sea ends where people stop being able to see it," he had said.

At first Lisa decided the globe was intended for sailors who got lost at home. Her father agreed that there could be difficult passages at home too, particularly from the sofa to the kitchen when you were being called to wash up.

He was a sailor by trade, rather than manner. He didn't use mysterious words over breakfast, call her mother "Captain," or forecast the weather from tea

leaves. But he tied knots so quickly that Lisa suspected he had extra fingers. When he came home, it took him a long time to get used to his cup not sliding off the table.

[5] She had read *Twenty Thousand Leagues Under the Sea* at six, first with his help, then by herself, from the first page to the last. Even the long lists of fish had been navigated: Lisa believed you couldn't throw away the inconvenient parts of a journey. Her father wrote nothing in the margins. He let her ask questions in the middle of a page, although this sometimes made one chapter last three evenings.

"Why does Captain Nemo have so many books?"

"Because one person's head is too small a place to live in."

"Isn't a submarine too small as well?"

"A head needs different doors."

With a fine black marker, Lisa traced the route of the *Nautilus* on her globe. Where she couldn't work out the route, she drew a dotted line. Her father called it an honest line.

"A solid line says, 'I know.' A dotted one says, 'I'm still working it out.'"

At ten, she learned the word "shipwreck" somewhere other than a book.

Adults said it in the next room, lowering their voices. Then other words appeared: search, information, list, suspended. Her father's name passed from one sentence to another without finding an ending. There was neither a homecoming nor a final answer. There were papers, conversations, and strangers who desperately wanted to say something useful and therefore said almost the same things.

Her mother didn't put his work jacket away immediately. Lisa noticed the empty hook and asked nothing. The globe stayed.

[6] Over the years she learned to live without waiting every day. She did her homework, went on to university, enjoyed her friends, got cross with broken taps. Her father's absence did not become her only occupation. But somewhere inside her, a room remained where the light had not yet been switched off.

On the first of December she came home between her classes and her evening errands, put the kettle on, and lit the little Sun and Moon.

Black routes circled the oceans. One line had a thick, ugly stretch: as a child, she had sneezed without lifting the marker. Her father had said the *Nautilus*

might perfectly well have made a detour if the captain had caught a cold too.

Lisa turned the Earth.

"Don't start," she told herself.

Then she took out reference books and old printouts about astronomy.

She had heard of the XMM-Newton space observatory: it studied the universe in X-rays and travelled in an elongated orbit. A matching altitude didn't turn the red line into evidence. Too much had been chosen arbitrarily: the length of a league, the direction, even the idea of measuring straight through the planet. There were plenty of

other spacecraft and other distances. Yet her mind readily connected these particular points.

A library in the sky.

A father who knew her favourite book.

A message left where she was certain to see it.

If he was alive, why didn't he come home? If he couldn't come home, why didn't he write plainly? If he needed help…

Lisa stopped, her palm resting on the globe. That last question had moved too fast even for her.

She understood the difference between a wish and a piece of information. In an exam she

would have given herself a failing mark for such a conclusion. But people rarely have to defend their own hopes in an examination.

Beneath her calculation she wrote: "Check what's possible. Don't present the rest as fact."

Then she wrote the address of the public observatory, where she could talk to someone for whom an orbit was a practical question.

Her mother looked into the room.

"Will you be home this evening?"

"I'm going to look at the sky."

"Take a hat."

Lisa looked at the little Moon. Its light was gentler than the Sun's; on her desk, evening and morning could exist at the same time.

"I will," she said.



4. A Point of Light Was Enough

The observatory smelled of cold metal and warm clothes. The two smells lived peaceably side by side, like people who had long since learned not to argue over who was in charge.

Lisa arrived towards evening and asked whether she could see XMM-Newton.

The man at the desk looked up. His name was Mikhail Pavlovich. He didn't put on the expression adults sometimes use to greet an unexpected question: one of ready-made condescension.

"The spacecraft itself, or what it sees?"

"The spacecraft."

"That's harder. Why?"

Lisa took out her notebook, but didn't show him the red inscription. She explained that she was interested in the orbit. It was true, just not all of the truth.

Mikhail Pavlovich looked at her calculation and asked where eighty thousand kilometres had come from.

"A book."

"Not a bad beginning. For an orbit, we'll need some more data afterwards."

He found information about the pass and spread the sheets before her. The geometry allowed a short evening window, approximately 17:24 to 18:28 local time. Conditions improved after 18:02, when it grew darker, but darkness alone promised nothing. Elevation above the horizon, illumination of the spacecraft, atmospheric clarity: all of it mattered.

[7] "At about six this evening it should be some thirty-four degrees above the horizon, at a range of roughly eleven thousand eight hundred kilometres," said Mikhail Pavlovich. "But 'it should be there' and 'we'll see it' are different statements."

Lisa nodded. She understood that distinction painfully well.

"If we do see it, will we be able to make anything out?"

"A point of light. Even if we're lucky. No solar panels, no details of the body. And I should make this clear now: it's an automated observatory, not a crewed station. There are no people aboard."

She looked down at her notebook.

"None at all?"

"None. It has a different purpose. There's no accommodation for people."

"No library, then, either."

He didn't laugh.

"Only if by a library you mean the data it collects. No bookshelves, though."

For a while they could hear someone shifting a crate in the next room. Lisa closed her notebook, then opened it again.

"My father was a sailor," she said. "He disappeared. A long time ago. Sometimes I put things together too quickly."

Mikhail Pavlovich didn't say he understood. He looked at her hands, at the pencil between her fingers.

"With things like that, even slowly can be difficult," he said.

That sentence allowed her to stay.

Once they began observing, Lisa discovered that waiting at an eyepiece had an entirely different length. A minute could consist of cold against her cheek, an eye in the wrong position, a request not to touch the telescope tube, and a sudden sense that the universe had managed perfectly well without her presence and had nevertheless allowed her a look.

At first there were only stars. Then Mikhail Pavlovich adjusted the pointing and asked her to watch one that wasn't the brightest.

A faint point shifted against the fixed pattern.

"There's a candidate," he said quietly. "Let's compare the motion."

[8] They were lucky that evening: the faint moving light appeared where the calculation suggested they might find the spacecraft. It was one small, fortunate observation, neither a miracle nor proof of any mystery. Mikhail Pavlovich checked the time and direction once again, and Lisa watched until her eye grew tired.

No window opened for her, no familiar face appeared. Nobody waved from an impossible deck.

Only a point of light.

And somehow it was enough for Lisa to think of the sky, for the

first time, as something other than a place to hide a lost person. It was somewhere towards which she could direct her own life.

"What do you need to work with things like that?" she asked, stepping away from the telescope.

"First, decide which things. Building spacecraft, processing observations, doing research: those are different paths."

"And if you want to fly?"

"That's another path. A long one. Selection, health, training, experience. A degree doesn't open the doors by itself."

"I'm not planning to go tomorrow."

Mikhail Pavlovich smiled.

"Then you can start today."

He paused and cleared the papers from the desk.

"After university I wanted to take that path too. I didn't pass the medical selection. For a long time it felt as if I'd been forbidden to love the sky. Then I realised that wasn't what I'd been forbidden. So I work here. I watch, I learn. Sometimes I show other people."

Lisa looked at him differently now.

"Don't you regret it?"

"Sometimes. And I love my work. The two don't always get in each other's way."

As she was leaving, she said:

"I'll come tomorrow."

"For this spacecraft, better in two days. Its orbit takes roughly forty-eight hours, but the time changes a little with each pass. Come on the third. I'll tell you when to be ready."

Outside, Lisa took out her notebook. Beneath "don't present as fact," she wrote: "After graduation, find out the selection requirements. Don't confuse a dream with an application. Start preparing."

She took the tram home. Her hat was reflected in the window, with dark houses trembling behind it. The rails knew where to go,

which made life easier for the driver. Nobody forbade the passengers to get off.

She hadn't deciphered the red line yet.

But she came home no longer quite the person who had left her notebook on the desk that morning.



5. A Timetable for the Sky

For Slava, the first of December ended considerably closer to the ground.

After classes he went to the library, asked for the returned Verne, and was given a book with a worn blue spine. There was a number inside the cover. He memorised it as carefully as people memorise a carriage number when someone important is leaving on the train.

In the space beneath the last line of a chapter, beside the description of Captain Nemo's library, Slava wrote in pencil:

Hello. How are you?

He looked at it and blushed. Two months of agonised preparation had produced a text suitable for addressing the next person in the bread queue.

But he left it alone. Too elegant an opening would require him to remain elegant ever afterwards, and he was counting chiefly on honesty and patience.

He returned the book. The librarian, Elena Borisovna, raised an eyebrow.

"Read it already?"

"Remembered it."

"That sometimes takes longer."

He couldn't tell whether she was joking, so agreed just in case.

Meanwhile, Lisa had drawn up a timetable for a very different library.

[9] After the first evening, she began coming every other day, as Mikhail Pavlovich had suggested. The calculations and changing times remained his responsibility; Lisa followed his instructions and didn't yet know how short this December sequence of meetings would prove. It had been explained to her at once: the arrangement gave them a chance to try, not a right to demand a point of light from the sky. Sometimes the weather interfered; sometimes a

faint object couldn't be distinguished even when everything looked quite promising on paper.

On the third of December she came with a thermos. On the fifth, without a thermos but with extra socks. On the seventh she brought Mikhail Pavlovich her calculations, with all the arbitrary assumptions circled separately. He praised the circles rather than the result.

Every two days, her appointment with the sky grew shorter.

Not because the sky was moving away. The convenient part of the spacecraft's motion was gradually shifting earlier, and

darkness had no intention of adjusting to someone else's orbit. At the beginning of the month they could afford several unsuccessful attempts at pointing the telescope. Later, they had to be ready beforehand. By mid-December, waiting at the telescope felt like making a connection with too few minutes to spare.

"The date's getting shorter," Lisa observed.

"A geometrical date," Mikhail Pavlovich clarified.

"They all involve geometry. Someone's too far away; someone's at the wrong angle."

Sometimes she saw a possible faint point. Sometimes only stars. None of those evenings brought news of her father, and Lisa diligently recorded exactly what she had observed, without additions. Her imagination continued its work, but now it had been allotted a separate page.

On that page there could be an improbable father, who had somehow survived and sent an obscure message from somewhere unknown. On the next were times, directions, uncertainties, and the honest words: "Unsuccessful."

She was learning not to put an equals sign between the pages.

By the seventeenth of December, only a few minutes of the good evening window remained. Lisa came early, checked her watch, and caught herself in an old childhood wish: if she paid close enough attention, the person she needed wouldn't disappear.

The person she needed did not appear. The spacecraft continued on its way.

On the nineteenth she came again, with her thermos and the particular calm that comes from a familiar sequence of actions. Mikhail Pavlovich met her at the desk, not at the telescope.

"I'm afraid there won't be anything more to see," he said. "In this evening window."

Lisa didn't understand at once.

"What do you mean? What about the day after tomorrow?"

He showed her a diagram. The spacecraft continued along its path, and the Earth along its own; the illumination and the position relative to the observer changed. Two days didn't return everything to exactly where it had been. A convenient elevation no longer coincided with a sufficiently dark sky.

[10] "It doesn't mean it's disappeared. We'll have to wait for the next suitable window.

Meanwhile, there are other things to look at."

Silently, she unscrewed the thermos lid, then screwed it back on. She wanted to object, as if the timetable had been cancelled through somebody's oversight.

"I thought there would still be time."

"I know," said Mikhail Pavlovich. "When I couldn't get through selection, at first all I could think about was the closed door. But the sky isn't contained in that doorway."

He didn't hurry her for an answer.

At last Lisa took out her notebook and wrote: "The window has ended. The spacecraft is still moving." This was news neither of her father's life nor of his death. Only of the limits of observation.

Then she returned a borrowed pamphlet and asked about preparation. Mikhail Pavlovich gave her a list of topics to begin with and advised her not to neglect her English.

"To speak English to the stars?"

"To the people who make the instruments."

"People are always more difficult."

He didn't disagree.

The next day, Lisa remembered the actual library.

She was standing in the middle of her room, fastening her overalls, when the meaning of the inscription suddenly turned the other way. Library. A book title. Not eighty thousand kilometres down. Not an encoded address in space. Just a book on a shelf.

Lisa sat on the edge of the bed.

"Very good, Ladina," she said. "Drilled straight through the planet. Never went into the reading room."

Laughing hurt a little, then made her feel lighter.

At the library, Lisa reminded Elena Borisovna of the Verne novel she had asked for at the end of November. The librarian took a volume with a worn blue spine from a small stack of books she had set aside.

"It waited for you."

"Suspiciously patient," said Lisa.

At home she opened the chapter about the library of the *Nautilus* and saw the pencilled words.

Hello. How are you?

A tram passed outside the window. The kettle began to hum. Not a single heavenly body altered its trajectory because of those words.

Lisa took a sheet of paper from her pocket.

Hello. Things are more complicated than your question. For a start: why did you write in my notebook without asking?

She put the sheet between the pages and returned the book the next day.



6. The Rules of a Folded Sheet

The answer appeared two days later.

Because I was too frightened to ask aloud. That's an explanation, not an excuse. I'm sorry. I won't write in your notebook again. Or here either, if you don't want me to.

No clever turn of phrase, no attempt to persuade her that the intrusion had been a compliment. Lisa reread the note and unexpectedly stopped being angry.

Not in my notebook. Here is all right, but on separate sheets. The

book has already survived more readers than you or I have. Who are you?

Slava spent almost the entire evening over his reply.

Someone from the shared lectures. You've seen me. I want to talk to you, but I'm not good at beginnings. I can tell you my name now.

Lisa could have demanded a name. Instead she remembered how readily she had ruled out almost everyone she knew, and felt the stirrings of a sporting interest.

Don't tell me yet. I'll try to recognise you from your answers.

But no invented life story or other people's heroic deeds.

I haven't many of my own.

All the easier to check.

And so they agreed on anonymity before it had time to become a trap.

[11] The book wasn't always available immediately. Other people wanted to travel aboard the *Nautilus* too, and none of them knew that they were unwittingly taking somebody's "are you tired today?" away with them. Sometimes a note came back in a day, sometimes a week. Lisa and Slava began leaving requests for the same books with Elena Borisovna, without trying

to persuade her to disclose another reader's details.

Naturally, the librarian noticed something odd. But her many years of experience suggested that people borrowed literature for the most peculiar reasons, and if the reason made them return the books on time, it was too soon to interfere.

After New Year, Lisa proposed a game.

As children, we used to fold a sheet of paper. The first person writes a statement and a question, then folds the statement out of sight so the next person sees only the question. The second answers with a new statement, asks a question

of their own, and hides the answer under another fold. And so on. At the end we unfold it and find out what we've made.

As an example, she wrote:

The sun is shining outside. Why am I hot?

She folded away the first line.

Slava read only the question and answered:

Because I put on a warm jumper. Where can I find some lighter clothes?

He hid his statement beneath a new fold. Only one question would remain for the next person. But the next person was Lisa again, and she wrote that

lighter clothes could be found in the wardrobe of someone who never felt cold, then asked where such people lived.

After several exchanges, the sheet resembled an accordion.

[12] Unfolded, the story began with sunny weather, passed through a jumper, a wardrobe, and the equator, and ended with a librarian lending blankets to sea turtles. Lisa laughed over it in the reading room and received a well-deserved reprimand.

They liked the game for different reasons. Lisa liked that a thought couldn't see its whole route in advance. Slava liked that answering one question was

easier than presenting the whole of himself at once.

But soon ordinary letters appeared beneath the folded sheets.

Do you like winter?

When winter's heating works properly.

Do you always ask so many questions?

No. According to my family, fewer in my sleep.

Why do you need a screwdriver?

Because screws exist.

Slava carried that last answer in his pocket for a long time.

They wrote about little things because large admissions hadn't yet learned to fit on paper. Lisa said she couldn't bear the word "obviously" where nothing had been explained. Slava admitted that he sometimes spent too long repairing something simply to avoid throwing away a thing that had served him well. She told him about the apples: if you eat on the run, you don't notice the taste, and the apple goes to waste. He told her about an old radio that he had first had to repair, and then wean himself off listening to at night.

In the lecture hall, everything remained the same. Lisa sat at the front on the left, Slava at the back

on the right. She considered possible correspondents in turn and found a discrepancy every time. Too talkative. Too pleased with himself. Doesn't read at all.

Again, she didn't think of Slava. Once he picked up a pen she had dropped, handed it to her, and left before she could ask whether he had missed the previous lecture.

Her invisible companion could write whole pages. This man clearly struggled with even two words.

Lisa didn't yet know that some doors open only from one side until someone patiently holds them from the other.

7. Minor Repairs to Winter

By February, their correspondence had acquired a weather of its own.

If Slava's reply was short, Lisa knew he was tired or stuck in his calculations. If Lisa asked three questions in a row without a joke between them, he knew the subject truly mattered. She rarely used exclamation marks, which gave them an almost official force.

One day the note consisted of a single sentence:

Today I don't understand anything.

Slava brought the book home, read the note, and began composing words of comfort. He wrote that everything would work out. Crossed it out. He didn't know whether everything would work out. He wrote that she was clever. That was true, but had little to do with not understanding today.

At last he answered:

Would you like to tell me what, exactly? Or would it be better today just to sit together on paper?

Lisa chose the second.

He left the next sheet blank, apart from two chairs drawn at the bottom. One was slightly smaller

than the other, for no symbolic reason: the first hadn't fitted properly.

She drew a table and two cups between the chairs.

They never filled that page with anything else.

Another time, Lisa told him about an argument with her mother. Her mother had no objection to space in principle. What she objected to was her daughter simultaneously having an unfinished thesis, forgotten warm gloves, and an existing plan to leave the planet.

We've agreed to start with the gloves, Lisa wrote.

Slava laughed, but then spent a long time looking at the words "leave the planet."

He knew she was preparing for a future in space-related work. Reading selection requirements, studying, finding out what further education and experience she would need. Now he understood that this wasn't an enthusiasm that would last until the first exam. After graduation, Lisa planned to move somewhere she could take the next real step. Her path might prove long and might never lead to a flight at all. That didn't make it any less real.

Slava found a clean sheet.

Have you decided to leave?

[13] *Yes. Not straight for space, if that's what you mean. First somewhere I can study and work genuinely close to the field. Then selection processes, training; a lot of it isn't up to me. But starting is.*

He wanted to write: "What if there's someone here who…"

Instead he asked:

Are you frightened?

Sometimes. But staying just because I'm frightened frightens me too.

After that note, Slava looked at the calendar for the first time as an object with a grievance against him.

September, October, and November he had spent working up the courage to leave a few words. December and January had learned to talk for him. Now there were only a few months left until graduation, and he could still spend them in the far right-hand corner, waiting for life to say his name on its own.

He didn't want her to give up her path. He wanted there to be a place for him along it. The difference was enormous, although both thoughts began with "I want."

At the end of February he sent a poem.

Or rather, the beginning of a poem which, in the course of composition, had collided with a tram.

The Pole Star shines within your eyes…

Several crossed-out lines followed. Then:

No ordinary star,
a guiding light by far—
it shows a tram the way…

Beneath the verses, Slava added:

At this point poetry got off at the stop. I couldn't catch up with it.

Lisa read the note twice. First she laughed. Then she stopped laughing: "within your eyes" had

unexpectedly robbed her of her usual assurance.

Until now, what was happening could have been called friendship, a game, curiosity. Now the words had opened a space where two people stood, and one was no longer entirely in hiding.

She didn't pretend not to have noticed.

I like the beginning. But why does a tram need a star? It has rails.

The reply came quickly:

Exactly. Everyone knows where it's supposed to go. School laid part of the track, family added a bend, everyone else explained

where the terminus was. Sometimes you want at least to see that the sky goes farther than the wires.

Lisa held the sheet in her palm.

Then let the star show the stop where you can get off. It would be a shame to put wings on a tram: it's useful as it is. But a person doesn't have to spend their whole life riding to the terminus.

Beside her reply, Slava placed a small dot that looked like a star if you regarded it with sufficient tenderness.

8. An Honest Line

Her father entered their correspondence in March.

Before then, Lisa had spoken of the globe, childhood reading, the sea, but she knew how to skirt the empty place so skilfully that she scarcely noticed herself doing it. One day Slava asked why she always chose books about journeys, even when she insisted she was tired of getting ready to go anywhere.

She began an answer about geography. Then put the paper aside. That evening she came back and wrote everything.

About being six and the *Nautilus*. About the shipwreck. About how the absence of final news is neither presence nor death: the people around you hurry to choose a familiar word for it, while none of their words will stay in place for you.

About the red inscription in her notebook and the altitude she had calculated.

I know it was an absurd interpretation, she wrote. *XMM is automated. They explained that straight away. But by then I'd had time to want my father to be alive there in particular, because it was somewhere I hadn't looked yet. A wish like that doesn't become*

information. It can simply be very strong.

Slava read the letter standing by the reading-room window.

He went cold. It had never occurred to him that a few words chosen out of shyness could reach so much deeper into someone else's life than he intended.

His first reply was too long. He explained that he hadn't known, defended himself in advance, promised never again. Then he saw that almost the entire letter was about himself, and took a fresh sheet.

I wrote that first message in your notebook. I heard you asking for Verne in the library and wanted to

begin a conversation through the book. I didn't know about your father. It wasn't a message from him or about him. I'm very sorry my puzzle touched that particular place. If you want, I'll tell you my name now and we can talk directly. If you don't want to reply again, I'll understand.

He left the note and scarcely slept for several days.

[14] Lisa received it on Thursday. At first she was angry, no longer at Slava, whom she hadn't yet recognised, but at the finality of a simple explanation. It felt as if the last layer were being carefully lifted from the red line, revealing not a mystery but human awkwardness.

She walked home. Then switched on the globe.

The line drawn after that childhood sneeze crossed the ocean in an absurd detour. Her father didn't stop being her father because the route had been drawn incorrectly. And uncertainty didn't become an answer when one mistaken guess fell away.

Lisa took a sheet of paper.

Thank you for telling me plainly. I invented the address in space myself; you aren't responsible for that. You are responsible for someone else's notebook, but we've settled that already. I need a little time. Then I'll write.

She returned to the observatory at the weekend, without that brief December wait. Mikhail Pavlovich showed her images and explained a problem he was working on. Neither her father nor the note came up in their conversation.

Lisa listened, asked questions, and gradually noticed something important: her interest remained. Even if the red inscription had only been an invitation to the library, she still wanted to know how the instruments worked, how the data were processed, how people prepared for work in which a mistake could cost so much.

The dream had survived the loss of its accidental starting point.

A week later she wrote to Slava:

I want to go on. And now I want to get to know you, rather than solve a note. Those are different things. We can leave the name until we meet, if you agree. But the meeting must be real.

He sat for a long time over the word "real."

I agree, he answered at last. *I want very much to see you.*

You see me in lectures.

That's different.

Yes, Lisa wrote. *I know.*

In the lecture hall she began to look more closely at people. She was no longer seeking the clever author of a puzzle. She was looking for someone who had known when to stop hiding behind one.

Once Slava lingered by the door while she put her things away. Lisa raised her head, and he almost said her name.

"You..." he began.

"What?"

"You haven't zipped your pocket. Your notebook will fall out."

She looked down.

"Thank you."

He left, berating himself silently and at length.

And Lisa suddenly smiled. She had no evidence. Only an odd feeling: in that brief concern, a familiar voice had managed to step out of the paper and immediately hide itself again.

9. Coordinates Without Degrees

In April, Slava began drawing a map.

At first it was an ordinary diagram of a few streets leading to the observatory. He walked the route three times, corrected a turn twice, and once bought a bread roll he had no need of whatsoever because Lisa was standing at the kiosk.

She was choosing tea and didn't notice him. He carried the roll home as material evidence of his inability to manage chance encounters.

[15] On his fourth walk, Slava stopped hiding from the city and looked at the route through her eyes. Here was a place where a narrow piece of the Volga could be seen from the pavement. Here was a tree that grew in an awkward place for a draughtsman but a good one for shade. Here was the tram stop: you could go farther from here, or get off.

The ordinary diagram became a letter.

Slava drew a dotted line. Without knowing what her father had said about an honest line, he chose one for much the same reason: an unbroken route looked like an

order. The gaps in a dotted line left room for air.

The last dot was at the observatory. Lisa had already told him enough about her first December evening there for him to understand that he couldn't invite her there simply to stage an impressive surprise. Too much of her life was in that place.

So he asked first.

Would you like to go there again one evening, when you don't have to catch sight of the spacecraft in time? Just to be under the sky. Not alone.

The answer was in the next book:

Yes. But before I agree to the route, tell me: is this an invitation?

Yes.

Then I accept. All that's left is to learn to read the map.

They didn't choose the day straightaway. Both had theses to write, consultations, exams, things that until spring had seemed far off and therefore optional. In due course they learned that the graduation celebrations were planned for 28 June. Lisa intended to leave a few days later.

After graduation would be right, she wrote. *At least one evening without an unfinished chapter hanging over me.*

You'll always find another chapter, Slava replied.

A new one is welcome. I'd like to hand in the unfinished old one first.

He made the map on a sheet of stiff paper that folded down to the size of a library card. Instead of latitudes and longitudes, it had a local grid: letters along the edges, numbered squares, symbols for the tram stop, the tree, the fence. At the bottom, among the explanations, he hid two pairs of numbers. Faint dots linked 28 to 06 and 20 to 00. Beside them was a little "after," underlined twice.

The date and time were no secret he was keeping from her, just the last part of the game: 28 June, eight in the evening, after graduation.

[16] Lisa liked finding the answer herself. Slava knew this. He had underestimated only one thing: a person in love can reread a note twenty times and never once turn the page over.

The map was on the back of one of their letters about roads. Lisa read the letter, slipped it into her personal notebook, and carried it with her for a long time. She thought about the words "not alone," smiled at the most inappropriate moments, and failed to notice the slightly

turned-back corner inviting her to unfold the paper all the way.

In his next message, Slava asked:

What do you think of the other side?

Lisa decided he meant the other side of some philosophical question and wrote a detailed reply about how every choice had its price, but that was no reason to choose nothing at all.

He read it and fell still further in love.

She still hadn't found the map.

So Slava drew a little arrow on a narrow slip and wrote: "Sometimes a thought carries on round the back." He put the slip

in the book as a bookmark, with the arrow pointing towards the edge of the page. Lisa turned the page of the book, read the continuation of a footnote on the other side, and decided he was referring to one of their old jokes.

"My God," Slava said to his radio. "She drilled through the Earth. But she can't turn over a piece of paper."

The radio answered with static. Judging by its tone, it was on her side.



10. One Book a Day

By June, Slava had realised that chance had far too much going for it.

The map might stay folded. The book they needed might be lent to another reader. A note might slip out. Lisa might finally decide that someone who had promised to meet her but wouldn't simply tell her the time was incapable of making up his mind.

The last possibility was almost true, which made it particularly troubling.

[17] He drew up a list of all the books they had spoken through. There were twelve: Verne, a

collection of stories, a book about the sky, two books borrowed for their studies that had unexpectedly proved useful for quite different questions. In one they had argued about whether silence counted as an answer. Another held the sheet with the two chairs. A third was memorable because Slava had once received it without a note and spent three utterly pointless hours before thinking to check the pages near the end.

He decided to leave a clue in every book they shared. One a day, not as part of some elegant design, but because during the day he was working on his thesis, helping his brother, and didn't

always have time for a long visit to the library.

He began on 14 June.

Into the first book he slipped a note: "There's another side to our road. Unfold the letter about roads all the way."

Into the second: "Coordinates aren't only found on a globe. Sometimes they're a day and an hour."

Into the third: "If the map refuses to open, I'll be waiting anyway: after graduation, in the evening, at the place where you first looked for your own point in the sky."

With each day the clues grew less mysterious. Slava discovered that in a crisis he was prepared to sacrifice literature for a precise address.

In the last note he wrote the date and time plainly. He folded it and left it in the book about stars. On the back he added: "If it doesn't suit you, write and tell me. We'll choose another time. This is an invitation, not an exam."

Now almost every street in their little paper town had a signpost.

Elena Borisovna watched his daily visits with growing respect.

"Revising for your thesis defence?"

Slava considered.

"I'm afraid of missing something important."

"Then don't just read the contents pages," she said.

Lisa found two clues on the same day.

She had come to return her textbooks and also borrowed the collection that held their first funny folded note. She wanted to gather up their correspondence before she left; the library books would have to stay where they belonged. Out of the collection fell the instruction to unfold the letter. Out of a second book came the reminder about coordinates.

Lisa sat down on the wide windowsill in the corridor, took out her personal notebook, and at last unfolded the stiff sheet completely.

The map lay before her.

[18] The dotted line went past the tram stop, the tree, the fence. The numbers formed pairs. She looked at the little "after" and laughed so loudly that Elena Borisovna looked out of the reading room.

"Is everything all right?"

"Yes. I've just spent a long time reading only one side."

"It happens with books," the librarian replied. "More often with people."

At home, Lisa laid the map beside the globe. At first she tried to work it all out like a problem, then realised she already knew most of the answer. The twenty-eighth. June. Eight in the evening. The observatory.

She circled the time in pencil and drew a little star beside it.

In reply she wrote:

Found the map. I'll come. To be clear: I've understood the day, the hour, and the place. I've also understood that you're ready to leave signposts for me in every book in the world.

Slava received the note the next morning.

Only in ours, he replied.

And for the first time in days, he could read to the end of a line without going back to the beginning.

11. A Day Without Lecture Notes

28 June arrived with no particular respect for how much was expected of it.

That morning, one of Slava's buttons came off. He sewed it on, pricked his finger, and decided that this took care of his necessary share of misfortune. He put on his elder brother's jacket, which fitted a little better now: he had finally had the sleeves shortened. The trousers had been hemmed too. He left his cap at home, then went back for it. Without it he felt as though he were trying to turn up at his own

rendezvous disguised as someone else.

Lisa put her hair in two braids. Her mother suggested wearing it loose, then looked at her face and didn't insist.

"Are you happy or nervous?"

"I haven't decided yet."

"You're allowed to be both."

For the ceremony, Lisa wore a light-coloured shirt and trousers. Her overalls were waiting at home with her trainers. She had already put her notebook, a pen, and the folded map into the bib pocket. It looked like the equipment for a short but important expedition.

Diplomas were handed out; speeches were made about the future. The future stood patiently along the walls and showed no one its timetable. Some already knew where they would work, some were planning to get married, some wanted at last to get enough sleep. No one was obliged to want the same thing.

Slava saw Lisa a few rows away. She was listening attentively, even when the speaker urged them for the third time not to forget the university. Then she turned and met his eyes.

He didn't look away.

Lisa smiled. Not broadly, not mysteriously. Simply as though

she had seen someone she knew and was pleased to see.

For a whole year Slava had thought he needed to learn to say something extraordinary. At that moment he realised that being able to bear an ordinary smile would be a good start.

After the ceremony they found themselves near each other in the courtyard. A few people passed between them, a camera flashed, someone called everyone over for photographs.

[19] "Congratulations," Slava said.

"You too. Are you going anywhere today?"

He looked at her.

Lisa let the silence last, looking perfectly innocent.

"This evening," he replied. "Yes."

"Good."

Someone called her, and she went to join the group photograph. Slava was left with the feeling that he had just been asked a question from the last exam card and had answered without knowing whether he had passed.

Lisa had almost worked it out. Not from his handwriting: in lectures he wrote differently, in a hurry, while in the notes he took pains. Not from his face: faces know how to keep quiet too. More from the way he left room for her answer. From a pocket that might

come open. From the awkward word "evening," which held a surprising amount of hope.

She didn't test her guess before the appointed hour. She wanted to go there herself, to walk the whole route rather than cut it short by unmasking him.

That afternoon they both attended to matters singularly unsuited to a momentous occasion. Slava helped his brother move a wardrobe. Lisa went out for bread, washed the cups, checked the documents she needed for her departure. Her mother asked whether she would be home late.

"I don't know. I'll call if I'm going to be late."

"Shall I spare you the advice about a hat, just this once?"

"I can go without a hat today."

Her mother nodded, then straightened the strap of Lisa's overalls on her shoulder.

"Off you go, then."

At the door Lisa hesitated and went back to her desk. A fine layer of dust slept on the globe. She ran a finger across the ocean, taking care not to rub away the black route.

"I'll tell you about it later," she said softly.

Not because she expected an answer from the room. Some words are spoken so as not to leave the people we love outside our new lives, even when we don't know where they are now.

Then she switched off both lamps and went out.

12. Eight O'Clock

Slava reached the observatory forty minutes early and immediately realised that forty minutes was far too much time for a man who didn't know what to do with his hands.

He walked around the courtyard, looked at the fence, read the notice he already knew almost by heart. Mikhail Pavlovich came out onto the steps for a moment.

Slava had visited him earlier to ask whether they could meet here in the evening. He wanted to make sure he wouldn't bring Lisa to a locked gate; no number of

clues would help against a good lock.

"Early?" Mikhail Pavlovich asked.

"A little."

"Sit down, then. Standing up to wait doesn't make time go any faster."

Slava sat down. A minute later he stood up.

Mikhail Pavlovich said nothing and went back inside.

Lisa followed the dotted line.

She knew these streets, but today she noticed a tree she had always walked past, the narrow strip of water between the houses, and the way a turn didn't reveal itself

all at once. The map wasn't telling her about an unfamiliar city. It showed her that someone had walked through a familiar one thinking of her.

At the stop, Lisa let a tram go by. It went on its way with its steady metallic sound. She watched it go and silently wished it good rails.

There were a few minutes left until eight.

Slava saw her from a distance: two braids, overalls, the map in her hand. From somewhere came one last absurd hope that she hadn't worked it out yet and he still had time to prepare the right words.

Lisa walked up and stopped in front of him.

"Hello. How are you?"

He laughed, surprising himself, easily and quite defencelessly.

"More complicated than your question."

"Then it all adds up."

They looked at each other. There was no one left to pass a book to, no page to fold, no way to buy a few days for an answer. But the danger, too, turned out to be different from what Slava had imagined: Lisa didn't demand that he suddenly become talkative. She simply stood beside him.

"I'm Slava," he said, and immediately blushed. "I mean, you know that."

"I do. I'm Lisa. Just in case."

"Did you work it out long ago?"

"I had my suspicions. I was sure today. But in December I ruled you out straightaway."

"Why?"

"You seemed too quiet for such outrageous behaviour."

"That's what I thought too."

She smiled, then grew serious.

"Thank you for telling me the truth about the first note, later on."

"I wish I'd told you sooner."

"You didn't know what I'd imagined then. Now you do."

He nodded. She wasn't forgiving him all over again or asking him to comfort her. She was simply making a place between them where important things no longer had to be skirted around.

Mikhail Pavlovich came through the open door. He congratulated them on graduating and asked Lisa about her plans. She gave him the short version: first work and further preparation, then trying to get through the necessary stages, if she had the health, the knowledge, and the perseverance.

"And if the road takes a turn?" he asked.

"I'll try to notice."

"That's a useful ability."

After he had gone, Slava asked how long she had known him.

"Since the first of December. He wanted to be a cosmonaut once too. After university he tried to head in that direction, but he didn't pass the medical. Then he found his work here. He says a love of the sky doesn't have to have only one outlet."

Slava looked at the door beyond which the footsteps had faded.

"I think he's right."

They sat on a bench. The summer evening still held the light, and the stars had no intention of appearing on demand, even to mark their graduation. Lisa liked that. For the first time, there was no particular point she had to catch sight of in time.

"I'm leaving," she said.

"I know."

"And I don't know how things will turn out for me."

"Neither do I."

She turned to him.

"Do you mean for me, or for you?"

"For both of us. I'll start work here in Volgograd. Then… I don't want to promise I know all the turns ahead. But I want to write to you. Without having to borrow a book."

"And come and visit?"

"If you want me to."

"I do. And I want to come and visit too. Only let's have no heroic deeds the other person is the last to hear about."

"Agreed."

Lisa took out her notebook, opened it to a clean page, and handed him the pen.

Slava looked at the white space, then at her.

"Am I allowed here?"

"This time I gave it to you myself."

[20] He wrote down his address and phone number. She wrote down hers, although her home number was unlikely to change any time soon, and promised to send her new one once she was settled. Their addresses took up only a few lines. Slava thought how long it had taken to reach such a simple page.

Then Lisa took his hand.

Slava gently closed his fingers around hers. Both their hands turned out to be quite ordinary: warm, a little awkward, with no literary training. They sat like that until they stopped thinking

about exactly how they were sitting.

"Did you finish the poem?" she asked.

"No. The tram's still getting in the way."

"Let it stay. I like it."

"Rails and all?"

"Especially the rails. You need to know what you're getting off."

He turned towards her, and Lisa leaned in to meet him. The kiss was brief. Afterwards, for some reason, it was easier to talk about quite ordinary things: his thesis, her mother, his brother's jacket, the unnecessary bread roll Slava had bought and then eaten

because otherwise the sacrifice would have been in vain.

When the sky grew dark enough, the first stars appeared. They offered no train timetables, made no promises about passing selection, and said nothing about the missing ship. Her father's fate remained unknown. Lisa no longer demanded that every distant point answer that one question, though she had not stopped loving him or hoping.

At the end of the evening they walked to the tram stop. Lisa folded the map and put it in her bib pocket. They no longer needed the route, but the paper would still come in useful.

At home, long after midnight, she switched on the globe and set her notebook beside it. On a fresh page she wrote the date, followed by two statements:

I don't know where the road will lead.

I know who I want to go on talking to.

Then she thought about a question, folded the page, and smiled. In the morning she could call.

The little Sun lit one half of the Earth. The other remained in darkness, where people lived too, where trams ran and words were lost and found.

Lisa turned the globe carefully, just a little.

The light reached farther.

The End

A Note from the Authors

The characters, their correspondence, their conversations, and the circumstances of their visits to the observatory are fictional. The Volgograd Planetarium and the XMM-Newton orbiting observatory are real. XMM-Newton is an automated scientific spacecraft; there are no people aboard.

The December viewing windows in the novella are based on calculations of the historical orbit, with local time taken into account. They represent geometrical opportunities for

observation, not archival evidence that the spacecraft was actually seen. For the series of visits depicted here, an assumed practical threshold is used: the spacecraft is more than twenty degrees above the horizon, the Sun is more than twelve degrees below it, and the spacecraft itself is illuminated. Brightness, atmospheric clarity, and the capabilities of the instrument also determine whether an observation succeeds. The successful sighting of a point of light on the first evening is fictional.

The straight line through the Earth in Lisa's reasoning and the direction of the telescope in the

evening sky are different lines. Her conjecture connects them emotionally, but does not make them a single physical point. No exact annual recurrence of the observation is assumed.

Sources for scientific verification: ESA historical orbital data, NASA/JPL Horizons ephemeris system, ESA information on XMM-Newton, the history of the Volgograd Planetarium's equipment.

The illustrations convey artistic impressions and are not documentary maps of the city.

A Question Without a Signature

In the margins: a separate story, “A Question Without a Signature.”

[1] Found an empty frame in a drawer. On the back, in pencil: “For something important.” No glass. Nothing important, either.

[2] Put it by the window. Take the price sticker off first. Somehow, the important thing already has a price.

[3] Done. The frame caught a drainpipe and half a cloud. I gave way to the pipe. It is fixed to the wall.

[4] Let the cloud leave when it wants to. We needn't keep it until the experiment is over.

[5] The cloud has gone. I stood the frame in front of my cup. Now the chip is right at the front. I used to turn that side towards the wall.

[6] That chip is how I always recognise your cup. You still shouldn't fill it right to the brim.

[7] A frame without a stand won't stay upright. I propped it up with a thick rubber. Now its most important job is not to fall.

[8] Brought a piece of wood. Try fitting the bottom edge into this

groove. I cut it myself, so keep hold of the frame at first.

[9] It fell as soon as I let go. One corner came apart. The groove's a bit shallow. At least we know about the old glue now.

[10] I've made the groove deeper. It stands now. Don't glue the corner yet. I want to see if the gap will hold a twig.

[11] We'll have a frame with a gap. A shop window would not approve.

[12] It holds. One end of the twig is inside, the other outside, and the frame's still standing. I'd leave it like that.

[13] I drew a house for the frame. Its roof came out too tall. There was enough paper, but not enough frame. I don't want to cut the roof off.

[14] Stand the frame in front of the paper, not flat against it. Leave a little air between them.

[15] From one spot I can see the whole roof. From another, only the door. I'll have to mark the proper place for the chair.

[16] Don't mark it yet. I want to try finding a place of my own.

[17] I moved the chair to the other side of the frame. There's "For something important"

again. I want to add exactly what it is for.

[18] I don't know today. We can come back tomorrow. Let's leave a little blank label beside it.

[19] I cut a label from an offcut of the wood and sanded the scratchy edge. The wording can wait.

[20] I put a pencil beside it. First, though, I want to look once more without it.

What will you leave room for, even if you cannot name it yet?